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The slur-epithet direction: the case of Italian

Abstract: We offer a new empirical argument from Italian in favor of the thesis that epithets (both in simple and binominal configurations) contain an indexical ingredient. The argument is based on the observation that Italian, unlike other Romance languages like Spanish, forces the use of weak demonstratives with epithets. We show that the use of these demonstratives correlates with the presence of a variety of empty nominal anaphora constructions. Epithets, then, form a natural class with this variety; concretely, they contain an empty noun headed by an index. Slurs, instead, are regular nominal heads in the extended projections of DPs or related nominal phrases. Consequently, they are compatible with the full array of determiner heads that the language allows. From this perspective, the difference between epithets (i.e., pure expressive) and slurs (mixed expressive) boils down to a difference in syntactic structure. We argue that epithets, particularly those derived from slur words, are merged in the functional spine of a pronominal DP, whose nominal head is instantiated by a mere index for an assignment function ranging over individuals. We conclude by showing the importance of the weak demonstrative test to distinguish at least two types of qualitative binominal constructions in Italian.

Keywords: epithets, slurs, demonstratives, empty nouns, Italian

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1 Introduction

Consider the following facts involving canonical slur words in (1) (McCready 2010) and epithets in (2) (Potts 2005):

- (1) a. *Andrés es puto.* (Spanish)
 Andrés is homosexual_{PEJ}
 ‘Andrés is a *f...*’
 b. *Ana es puta.*
 Ana is prostitute_{PEJ}
 ‘Ana is a *wh...*’
- (2) a. *el puto de Andrés*
 the EPITHET of Andrés
 ‘that *f...* of Andrés’
 b. *la puta de Ana*
 the EPITHET of Ana
 ‘that *b...* of Ana’

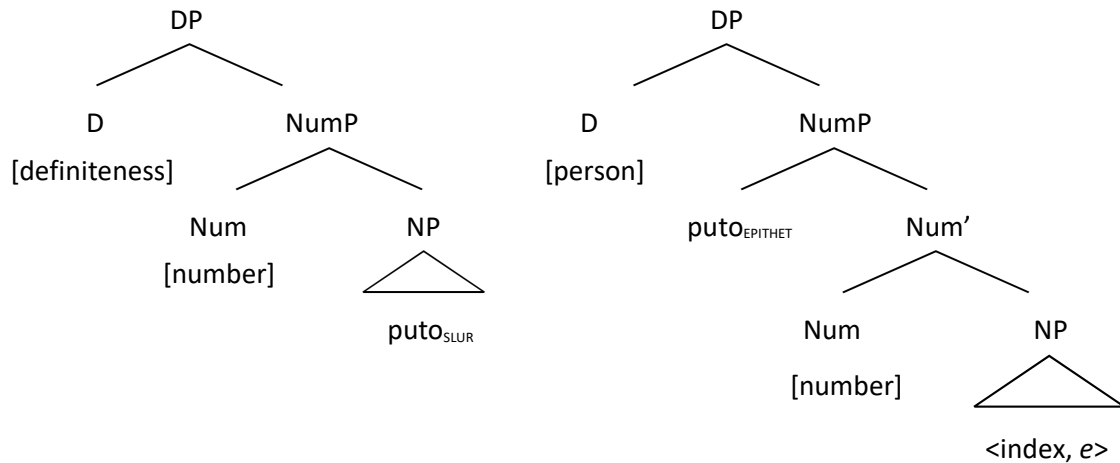
A crucial distinction between the two types of expressives is that whereas slurs are mixed terms with both an expressive and a descriptive component, epithets are pure expressive items, with no contribution to the truth-conditional dimension (see Gutzmann 2015, 2019 for a taxonomy in a bidimensional framework). Concretely, according to Orlando & Saab (2020b), the expressive dimension for both terms is modelled as a certain type of stereotype. The paradigm in (1)-(2) makes the difference clear enough. A crucial question is why and how a slur word, say *puto*, loses its predicative import when occurring as an epithet. In a series of works, Saab (2022b, 2025a,b) and Orlando & Saab (2020a) argue that the source of the difference is essentially syntactic. The idea is that the same lexical item can have a predicative and a non-predicative occurrence, called its *recycling position*.¹ This is stated in the following thesis:

- (3) Recycling thesis: Epithets are merged in a non-predicative position, in the extended projection of an indexical DP.

¹ There is an interesting connection between expressive recycling and well-known processes of grammaticalization. For a given slur to become an epithet not only the syntactic position is relevant, but also some lexical impoverishment of the descriptive dimension of the slur. In this study, we will only be concerned with the syntactic aspects of recycling.

The trees below illustrate the thesis with the slur and the epithet in (1a) and (2a), respectively. We assume that the non-predicative position in (4b) is Spec,NumP, but it could be another position in the functional spine of DPs.

- (4) a. The representational syntax of slurs: b. The non-representational syntax of epithets:



These structures amount to the following two (simplified) LFs. We use the diamond and the bullet in a rather vague way to distinguish mixed expressives from pure ones (E = epithet, S = slur):

- (5) *El puto_{E/S} llegó tarde.*
 the homosexual arrived late
 'The *f...*/That *f...* arrived late.'

Slur interpretation: *the homosexual* arrived late ♦ a homosexual stereotype is in force in *c*

Epithet interpretation: *he* arrived late • homosexual-stereotype(*x*)

The main goal of this paper is to present new evidence from Italian in favor of an indexical component in epithets. Unlike Spanish and related Romance languages, Italian epithets require the mandatory presence of the demonstrative *quel* 'that' (see Cardinaletti 2024 and Pescarini 2024 for recent discussion):

- (6) a. *È arrivato {il / quel} frocio_S.*
 is arrived the that homosexual_{PEJ}
 'The/that *f...* has arrived.'

- b. {**il* / *quel*} *frocio_E* *del* *tuo* *amico*
 the that EPITHET of-the your friend
 ‘your friend, that f...’

As we will show, the exclusive use of the demonstrative with epithets undoubtedly diagnoses the presence of the indexical ingredient in (6b).² The paper is structured as follows. In section 2, following the previous work already mentioned, we offer an overview of the recycling thesis and its implementation in Spanish and English. In section 3, we highlight the importance of the Italian evidence in the domain of slurs and epithets. In a nutshell, we show that the use of the demonstrative in examples like (6b) correlates with the presence of empty nominals/ellipsis in the language. Those empty nominals denote indexes for assignment functions ranging over individuals, i.e., they are indexicals. In section 4, we extend the indexical analysis proposed for English and Spanish to Italian and discuss the correlation between weak demonstratives and empty nouns in qualitative binominals. In the concluding section, we summarize the results and briefly comment on another type of Italian binominals, which do not require the demonstrative. This points to a new taxonomy of qualitative binominal DPs, which includes two basic types, namely: (i) those that contain the indexical ingredient, and (ii) those that do not.

2 A systematic syntactic ambiguity: previous evidence from Spanish and English

Let's consider the ambiguity in (5) again, repeated as (7):

- (7) *El* *puto_{E/S}* *llegó* *tarde*.
 the *f...* arrived late

Slur interpretation: *the homosexual* arrived late ♦ a homosexual stereotype is in force in *c*

Epithet interpretation: *he* arrived late ● homosexual-stereotype(*x*)

According to the rough representations provided below (7), the item *puto* is interpreted either as a mixed slur or as an epithet, i.e., as a mere insult. On this second interpretation, the DP *el*

² Note that there is inter-speaker variation in the acceptability of the article in examples like (6b), which is apparently based on regional differences. In particular, speakers from the North show the pattern in (6b), while speakers from Rome southwards are more permissive as far as the use of the definite article with epithets is concerned. For our concerns, the existence of a variety of Italian in which the article is possible with epithets is not problematic, because these speakers behave like Spanish speakers. What is crucial for us is that at least for some varieties of Italian the demonstrative is the only possibility, as shown in (6b). This paper is thus based on the grammar of the speakers who reject the use of articles with epithets, and the judgements given in the examples refer to this grammar.

puto only denotes the value of a given assignment function. In Orlando & Saab (2020a) and a series of related works by the same authors, such an ambiguity has a structural source. In this section, we offer an overview of the diagnostics provided by Orlando & Saab to set the background for the Italian facts relevant to the present study.

There are at least five quite robust tests that allow us to disambiguate the two relevant readings in (7). The first one has to do with the distribution of slurs and epithets in antilogophoric and Principle-C environments. As is well known, there is a long-standing debate regarding the anaphoric nature of epithets. Jackendoff (1972) famously claimed that they have the distribution of pronouns. His argument is based on the interpretation of epithets in cases like (8) (antecedents underlined):

- (8) a. *I wanted Charlie to help me, but the bastard wouldn't do it.*
- b. *Irving was besieged by a horde of bills and the poor guy couldn't pay them.*
- c. *Although the bum tried to hit me, I can't really get too mad at Harry.*

(Jackendoff 1972: 110)

A rule of pronominalization changing the relevant DPs for mere pronouns (e.g., *the bastard* → *he*) would fail at capturing the expressive content of epithets. Therefore, in order to account for the coreference patterns between epithets and its corresponding antecedents in each of the relevant sentences in (8), Jackendoff proposes to treat epithets as a class of “special pronouns”, which he called “pronominal epithets” (Jackendoff 1972: 110-111). Yet, Lasnik (1976) noticed that this view fails to account for the ungrammatical sentences in (9):

- (9) a. **John realizes that the sissy is going to lose.*
- b. **He realizes that the sissy is going to lose.*
- c. **The sissy realizes that the sissy is going to lose.* (Lasnik 1976: 11)

Changing the embedded epithet for a “normal” pronoun would make all the intended coreferences perfectly felicitous (e.g., *John* realizes that *he*...). It seems, then, that epithets behave as R-expressions (i.e., definite descriptions or proper names), as witnessed by the comparison between (9) and (10), that contains R-expressions in the embedded position:

- (10) a. **John realizes that John/the lawyer is going to lose.*
- b. **He realizes that John/the lawyer is going to lose.*
- c. **The sissy realizes that John/the lawyer is going to lose.*

Because of this type of empirical consideration, Lasnik treats epithets and R-expressions as similar referential expressions subject to his no-coreference rule, i.e., the predecessor of Principle-C of Binding Theory. In principle, the new approach covers both the facts in (8) and (9), since the antecedents *c*-command the epithets in (9) but not in (8), allowing thus co-reference but not binding in the latter (binding requires *c*-command). The *c*-command relations in (9), instead, force binding in a clear infraction of Principle-C of Binding Theory (i.e., R-expressions must be free (not bound) in their governing category).

Yet, as originally noted by Dubinsky & Hamilton (1998), the R-expression approach to epithets does not account for the following contrasts:

- (11) a. *John_i ran over a man (who was) trying to give the idiot_i/ *John_i directions.*
 b. *Through an accumulation of slip-ups, John_i (inadvertently) led his students to conclude that the idiot_i/ *John_i couldn't teach.*

(adapted from Dubinsky & Hamilton 1998: 689)

Here, the antecedent *John* can co-refer with the epithet but not with the R-expression. As is clear, the impossibility of co-reference with R-expressions follows as standard violations of Principle-C, but the pattern with epithets is totally unexpected under Lasnik's approach. For this reason, Dubinsky & Hamilton recover Jackendoff's original insight that epithets are "special pronouns" and make sense of their peculiarities through the introduction of an antilogophoric restriction in the distribution of epithets.

- (12) Antilogophoricity constraint for epithets: An epithet must not be anteceded by an individual from whose perspective the attributive content of the epithet is evaluated.

(Dubinsky & Hamilton 1998: 689)

The constraint is violated in (9) but not in (11), in which there is no coincidence between the perspective-bearer and the antecedent, making pronominal coreference legit.³

As noted by Orlando & Saab (2020a), it is possible to disambiguate the slur and epithetic readings in (7) by making use of antilogophoric environments in the favored sense. On this view, it is correctly predicted that a syntactic and semantic environment like (13a) cannot tolerate either

³ It is not clear how to account for the infelicitous coreference in (i), in particular, under a possible *de re* reading of the attitude predicate, according to which the attitude-bearer is the speaker and not the antecedent:

(i) **John_i believes that [the idiot]_i cannot do it.*

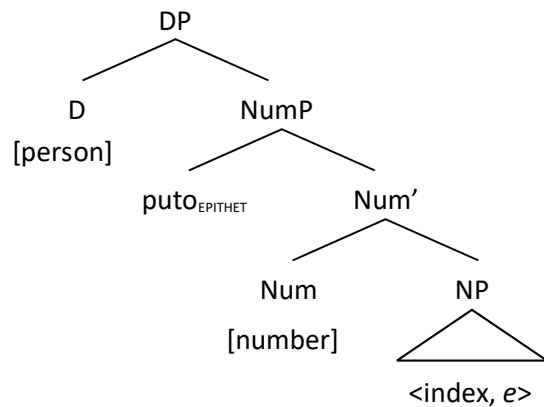
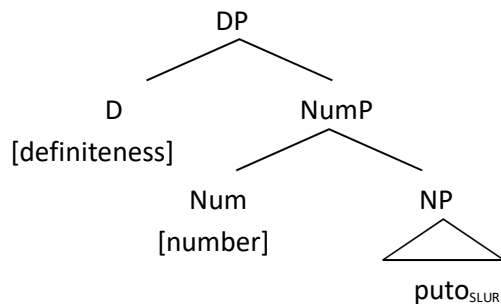
We will leave this problem unresolved here, as it is orthogonal to our main point in this study.

slurs or epithets. The sentence (13a) is ruled out as a standard infraction of Principle-C under the slur reading, but as an antilogophoricity constraint violation under the epithetic reading. Now, if we manipulate the antilogophoric environment by changing the perspective-bearer but maintaining the relevant c-command dependency, we predict that epithets, but not slurs, could co-refer with their antecedent. As the example in (13b) shows, the prediction is borne out:

- (13) a. **/#Andrés_i dijo que [el puto_{E/S}]_i llegó tarde.*
 Andrés said that the EPITHET/SLUR arrived late
 'Andrés said that the [EPITHET/f...] arrived late.'
- b. *Andrés es tan extrovertido que todos piensan*
 Andrés_i is so outgoing that everyone thinks
*que [el puto_{E/*S}]_i se va a meter*
 that the EPITHET/SLUR SE goes to put
en problemas con la policía.
 in troubles with the police
 'Andrés_i is so outgoing that everyone thinks that the [EPITHET/*SLUR]_i is going to get in trouble with the police.'

Assuming that in its slur occurrence *puto* has the syntax in (4a) (repeated as (14a)) and the epithet has the syntax in (4b) (repeated as (14b)), we capture the contrasts in (13).

- (14) a. The representational syntax of slurs: b. The non-representational syntax of epithets:



In addition to differences in co-reference constraints, the two readings can also be disambiguated through other properties: first, intensifiers like *muy* ‘very’ can only modify epithets, not slurs:⁴

- (15) *El muy puto_{E/*S} llegó tarde.*
 the very EPITHET/*SLUR arrived late
 ‘That complete f... arrived late.’

Second, qualitative binominals also disambiguate in favor of the epithetic readings (see also the examples in (2)). So, if we change the subject DP in (7) for a qualitative binominal, the predicative reading, typical of slur words, vanishes. Put differently, the word *puto* in (16) can only be interpreted as an epithet:

- (16) *El puto_{E/*S} de Andrés llegó tarde.*
 the EPITHET/*SLUR of Andrés arrived late
 ‘That f... Andrés arrived late.’

Other tests disambiguate in the opposite direction. So, the analyses in (14) predict that only slurs can be subject to canonical NP-ellipsis, a deletion operation that targets NPs, with exclusion of their extended functional projections (see Saab 2019). Since slurs head regular NPs, there is no reason why they cannot be subject to nominal ellipsis. As illustrated in (17a), the prediction is borne out; slurs can be elided by NP-ellipsis. This is not the case with epithets, which do not head any extended DP projection. The example in (17b) shows that an indubitable occurrence of an epithet in qualitative binominal environments like those in (16) cannot be elided, a fact that robustly points out to the conclusion that epithets are not canonical nominal heads (<...> = elliptical site).

- (17) a. *el puto de al lado y el <puto> de arriba*
 the SLUR of to.the side and the SLUR of upstairs
 ‘the f... next doors and the one living upstairs....’
 b. **el puto de Andrés y el <puto> de Pablo*
 the EPITHET of Andrés and the EPITHET of Pablo

Finally, consider restrictive modification. As expected, only slurs, i.e., true nominal predicates, allow for canonical modification by, say, restrictive adjectives:

⁴ Noun intensification must not be confused with degree modification, which in Spanish can also be expressed by *muy* ‘very’. Indeed, note that the epithet rejects pure degree modifiers (e.g., **demasiado/poco/bastante puto* ‘too/little/enough EPITHET’) typically attested with degree adjectives.

- (18) a. *el puto inteligente de arriba*
 the SLUR intelligent of upstairs
 ‘the intelligent *f*... living upstairs’
- b. **el puto inteligente de Andrés*
 the EPITHET intelligent of Andrés

Table 1 summarizes the main differences between epithets and slurs discussed so far.

Table 1: Epithets vs Slurs

Syntactic class	Syntactic position	Antilog. effects	Principle-C effects	Intensification	Binominal occurrence	Nominal ellipsis	Restrictive modification
Epithet	Spec, NumP	yes	no	yes	yes	no	no
Slur	NP head	no	yes	no	no	yes	yes

Importantly, as Orlando & Saab (2020a) show, the ambiguity also arises in other languages. Consider English, where the same ambiguity in (7) arises, witness (19):

- (19) *That whore_{E/S} arrived late at the party.*
- a. Slur interpretation: That prostitute arrived late at the party ♦ a misogynistic stereotype is in force in *c*
- b. Epithet interpretation: She (namely, the woman referred to in the context of utterance) arrived late to the party • misogynistic-stereotype(*g*(she))

Like in Spanish, antilogophoricity environments can be used to disambiguate between the two readings. In (20a), again, there is no way to embed either a slur or an epithet, because of Principle-C and the antilogophoric restriction, respectively. Now, in the sentence in (20b), in which antilogophoricity is avoided, a DP containing an epithet can be used with the intended coreference, but a slur DP is banned:

- (20) Antilogophoricity/Principle-C effects (Orlando & Saab 2020a):
- a. **/#Alice_i said that [the whore_{E/S}]_i had arrived late.*
- b. *Mia_i is so talkative that everybody thinks that [the whore_E]_i will get into trouble with the police.*

Also like in Spanish, only epithets can be intensified:

- (21) Intensification:
 *That complete(*ly) whore_E arrived late.* (Orlando & Saab 2020a)

As shown in Saab (2025a), although English does not have NP-ellipsis of the Spanish type, *one* anaphora can also be used as a similar diagnostic to disambiguate in favor of the slur reading. Thus, in (22a) a slur can be replaced by the nominal anaphora *one*. The same replacement is impossible for an indubitable occurrence of an epithet like *that whore Mary*, since, as we already have seen, epithets do not head the lexical domain of extended DP projections.

(22) One-anaphora:

a. *I'm talking about that annoying whore_s, not this charming one.*

b. **that annoying whore_e Anne and this charming one Mary*

In summary, the attested ambiguity of examples like (7) in Spanish or (19) in English can be derived as a case of structural ambiguity. Concretely, the same word can occur either as a nominal predicate heading the lexical layer of a given extended DP or as a nominal modifier, merged in the functional spine of the extended projection of a DP headed by a mere index subject to an assignment function. In the next section, we focus on Italian, a language that provides robust evidence for the distinction just made.

3 Italian

In this section, we offer our main empirical argument in favor of the indexical analysis for epithets based on the distribution of weak demonstratives in Italian epithets. In §3.1, we first show that the same ambiguity observed for Spanish (7) and English (19) can be detected in Italian through the same tests we used in the previous section. In §3.2, we discuss in more detail the distribution of weak demonstratives in Italian following recent work by Cardinaletti (2024) and Pescarini (2024). As we will see, there is a robust correlation between this type of demonstratives and empty nouns, including empty indexical nouns.

3.1 Epithets and slurs in Italian

In Italian, a sentence like (6) above can be formulated by using either a definite article or a demonstrative. Here is a similar example:

- (23) È *arrivata* {*la /quella*} *puttana*_{S/E}.
 is arrived {the/that} prostitute_{PEJ./EPITHET}
 'The/that *b...* has arrived.'

However, the distribution of the article and the demonstrative pronoun does not completely overlap: when *puttana* 'prostitute.PEJ' is used as a slur, both an article and a demonstrative can

be used. When it has an epithet reading, only the form of the distal demonstrative *quello* can be used. The examples in (24) show the difference:⁵

- (24) a. È arrivata {la/una/questa/quella} puttana_S.
 is arrived {the/a/this/that} prostitute_{PEJ}
 ‘The/that b... has arrived.’
- b. È arrivata {*la/*una/*questa/quella} puttana_E.
 is arrived {*the/*a/*this/*that} prostitute_{EPHET}
 ‘The b... has arrived.’

Note that the demonstrative *quella* in (24b) does not carry a deictic value (or it only very marginally does so): it is a “weak” demonstrative.⁶ “True” demonstratives (with deictic value) are ruled out in epithets, as shown by the fact that the proximal demonstrative *questa* (which is

⁵ Note that when *questo* ‘this’ and *quel* ‘that’ are used as “true” deictic demonstratives (24a), they behave like a definite determiner of D category. In what follows, for ease of exposition we only contrast the definite article with the weak demonstrative, without considering “true” demonstratives.

⁶ Weak demonstratives used with epithets (as in (24b)) are reminiscent of Pescarini’s (2024) “light demonstratives”, which are also used in non-deictic contexts: for example, in free relatives (i) and, crucially, when NP-ellipsis occurs (ii):

- (i) Dimmi quello che pensi.
 tell.IMP=me that.DEM that.COMP think.2SG
 ‘Tell me what you’re thinking.’
- (ii) Ho visto il figlio di Gianni, non quello <figlio> di Luca.
 have.1SG seen the son of Gianni not that son of Luca
 ‘I saw Gianni’s son, not Luca’s.’

We come back to NP-ellipsis in §3.2. In addition to their non-deictic value, weak and light demonstratives share the fact that they both correspond, in Spanish, to definite articles, and that they need not be anaphoric (i.e., they do not need to have been already introduced in the discourse). By contrast, weak demonstratives differ from light demonstratives because:

- light demonstratives always display the full forms *quello* and *quelli* (in the masculine), while weak demonstratives have the short forms *quel* and *quei* (like true demonstratives);
- light and weak demonstratives can be used in different types of binominal constructions: those that feature a light demonstratives require an intonational break after the noun, and the following PP takes a bare noun as complement; binominal constructions with weak demonstratives (which are the topic of this paper) have no intonational break, and the PP selects a DP, cf. (iii-iv), and see also (25) and the discussion about binominals below:

- (iii) quello frocio, di cameriere
 that homosexual_{PEJ} of waiter
 ‘the f... one among the waiters.’
- (iv) quel frocio del cameriere
 that homosexual_E of-the waiter
 ‘the waiter, that f...’

We thank Diego Pescarini (p.c.) for discussing the differences between weak and light demonstratives with us.

always deictic) is ungrammatical in (24b), unlike in (24a). As a matter of fact, in the case of slurs any “true” determiner is acceptable, if it is compatible with the context. Thus, Italian neatly differs from Spanish, in which the same element (the article *el/la*) is used with both slurs and epithets; therefore, in these languages many sentences are ambiguous between the two readings. In Italian, instead, the use of the article can be used as a test to distinguish between epithets and slurs.

Robust evidence for the complementary distribution of articles and weak demonstratives is provided by binominals, which, as we have seen, require an epithet (cf. (6b) above): as example (25) shows, in Italian they reject the presence of the definite article, unlike in Spanish (see Property #3 below):⁷

- (25) {*quella/*la*} *puttana*_{E/*S} *di* *Giulia*
 {that.F.SG/the.F.SG} EPITHET/*SLUR of Giulia
 ‘that *b...* Giulia’

The example (25) differs from (23) because the latter is in principle compatible with both an epithet and a slur reading (modulo the use of the article or the demonstrative), while (25) has, for independent reasons, only the epithet reading (see §4.2). The same contrast can be seen with any other epithet that is derived from a slur, as (26)-(29) show:

- (26) a. *È arrivato* {*il/quel*} *fascio*_{E/S}.
 is arrived {the/that} fascist_{E/S}
 ‘The/that fascist has arrived.’
 b. {**il/quel*} *fascio*_{E/*S} *del mio cugino*
 {**the/that*} fascist_{E/*S} of-the my cousin
 ‘my cousin, that fascist’
- (27) a. *È arrivato* {*il/quel*} *frocio*_{E/S}.
 is arrived {the/that} homosexual_{E/S}
 ‘The/that *f...* has arrived.’
 b. {**il/quel*} *frocio*_{E/*S} *del tuo amico*
 {**the/that*} homosexual_{E/*S} of-the your friend
 ‘your friend, that *f...*’

⁷ Note that the article would be grammatical in (25) if *puttana* ‘bitch’ is interpreted as a slur, but in this case, we are forced to interpret *di Giulia* ‘of Giulia’ as a possessive PP, thus excluding the qualitative binominal interpretation. The same observation holds for examples (26)-(29).

- (28) a. *È arrivato {il/quel} ne*ro_{E/S}.*
 is arrived {the/that} black_{E/S}
 'The/that *n*... has arrived.'
- b. *{*il/quel} ne*ro_{E/*S} del negoziante*
*{*the/that} black_{E/*S} of-the dealer*
 'the dealer, that *n*...'
- (29) a. *È arrivata {la/quella} zoccola_{E/S}.*
 is arrived {the/that} prostitute_{E/S}
 'The/that *b*. has arrived.'
- b. *{*la/quella} zoccola_{E/*S} della tua amica*
*{*the/that} prostitute_{E/*S} of-the your friend*
 'your friend, that *b*...'

This observation is confirmed by the entire set of properties of slurs and epithets listed above (cf. Table 1). Consider first epithets: they can be used in antilogophoric environments (Property #1), and with an intensifier (Property #2). As described in §2, in antilogophoric environments the epithet cannot have as antecedent an individual from whose perspective the content of the epithet is evaluated. This is shown in (30): the use of a weak demonstrative triggers the epithet reading, which is allowed in antilogophoric contexts. The article is ungrammatical here, because it would turn the interpretation of *stronzo* 'asshole' and *frocio* 'homosexual.PEJ' into a slur, and slurs cannot be coindexed with the subject of the main clause because of Principle-C:⁸

- (30) a. *Marco_i è così antipatico che tutti pensano che*
 Marco is such unfriendly that all.PL think.3PL that
*{*lo/quello} stronzo_i non troverà mai una fidanzata.*
*{*the/that} asshole not find.FUT.3PL never a girlfriend*
 'Marco is so unfriendly that we all think that the asshole will never find a girlfriend.'
- b. *Paolo_i se la tira così tanto che tutti pensano*
 Paolo REFL CL.ACC.F.SG takes so much that all.PL think.3PL
*che {*il/quel} frocio_i rimarrà presto senza amici.*
 that {the/that} homosexual leave.FUT.3SG soon without friends
 'Paolo boasts so much that everyone thinks that *f*... will soon run out of friends.'

⁸ More precisely, in (30a) the use of the article would trigger a literal interpretation of *stronzo* 'piece of shit', which of course could not be coindexed with the subject Marco.

The examples in (31) illustrate the use of intensifiers. If we add *grandissimo/a* ‘very big’, we are sure that we are dealing with an epithet and not with a slur. Again, only the weak demonstrative is allowed, while the definite article yields an ungrammatical result:

- (31) a. *Non sopporto* *{*il/quel}* *grandissimo* *frocio_{E/*S}*
 NEG stand.1SG *{*the/that}* big.SUPERL homosexual_{E/*S}
 ‘I can’t stand that complete f...’
- b. *{*La/Quella}* *grandissima* *puttana_{E/*S}* *mi* *ha* *chiamato* *ieri*.
*{*the/that}* BIG.SUPERL whore_{E/*S} me has called yesterday
 ‘That b... called me yesterday.’

By contrast, in environments in which only slurs are admitted, the slur can be headed by the definite article and other D heads, while the weak demonstrative is barred. These contexts concern NP-ellipsis (Property #4) and restrictive modification of the slur (Property #5). Regarding NP-ellipsis, consider the contrast between (32a)/(33a) and (32b)/(33b): the first example shows ellipsis within a ‘regular’ DP, in which the slur is followed by a PP indicating origin. In these sentences, the overt slur is preceded by the definite article. In the case of the (b) examples, instead, two epithets are used, as witness by the fact that the first of them is headed by the weak demonstrative.⁹ To make sure that this is indeed an epithet and not a slur (and thus to avoid its recovery as a slur with a ‘true’ demonstrative), we use two binominal expressions here (32b)/(33b):

- (32) a. *il crucco di Monaco e quello <crucco> di Amburgo*
 the SLUR of Munich and that <SLUR> of Hamburg
 ‘the kraut from Munich and that from Hamburg’
- b. **quel crucco di Hans e quello <crucco> di Dieter*
 that EPITHET of Hans and that <EPITHET> of Dieter
- (33) a. *la puttana di Napoli e quella <puttana> di Milano*
 the SLUR of Naples and that <SLUR> of Milan
 ‘the Neapolitan b... and that from Milan’
- b. **quella puttana di Maria e quella <puttana> di Lisa*
 that EPITHET of Maria and that <EPITHET> of Lisa

⁹ Note that the relevant part of the examples (32)–(33) is the first, where the antecedent of ellipsis occurs. The elided part, instead, always requires the use of the weak demonstrative *quello*, irrespective of the type of elided DP.

As these examples show, the use of the weak demonstrative triggers the epithet interpretation ((b) examples), which cannot be elided. This is expected if they are not ‘true’ nominal heads of DPs, unlike slurs.

The second property in which only slurs can be used is restrictive modification. Here again, examples (34a)/(35a) feature a slur, which can be modified through a PP or an adjective. By contrast, the examples (34b)/(35b) show the use of an epithet (as attested by the fact that they are inserted in a binominal expression): in this case, the epithet cannot be restrictively modified. Note that, again, the use of the weak demonstrative *quel* turns the expression into an epithet, while the definite article is associated with the slur interpretation:¹⁰

- (34) a. *la zoccola_S del piano di sotto*
 the prostitute_{PEJ} of-the floor of down
 ‘the b... living downstairs’
- b. **quella zoccola_E del piano di sotto di Carla*
 that EPITHET of-the floor of down of Carla
- (35) a. *il fascio_S biondo*
 the fascist_S blonde
 ‘the blonde fascist’
- b. **quel fascio_E biondo di Paolo*
 that fascist_E blonde of Paolo

In summary, the properties listed in Table 1 are transparently instantiated in Italian. The next step is to make sense of the occurrence of the mandatory use of the weak demonstrative. In §3.2, we show that it correlates with the underlying occurrence of an empty or elided nominal.

3.2 The correlation between empty nouns and epithets

Now, a question that arises from the Italian data seen so far concerns the use of a weak demonstrative with epithets. In particular, we would like to know why it is obligatory, and how the contrast with Spanish (cf. §2) can be accounted for.

A first observation we would like to make in this respect is that the contrast between Italian and Spanish in the distribution of demonstratives is not limited to epithets, but it is also found in

¹⁰ Note that modification is allowed in epithets only if it is part of the epithet itself, thus forming a fixed expression. The most common case is *figlio/figlia di* ‘son/daughter of’ + prostitute_{PEJ}.

cases of NP-ellipsis (cf. Leonetti 1999, Kornfeld and Saab 2004, Saab 2022a,b, Cardinaletti 2024, and Pescarini 2024):

- (36) a. *la casa di Maria e {*la/quella} <casa> di Carlo* (Italian)
 b. *la casa de María y {la/aquella} <casa> de Carlos* (Spanish)
 the house of Maria and {the/ that} <house> of Carlo
 Lit. ‘Maria’s house and the/that of Carlo’
- (37) a. *i libri che ho letto e {*i/quelli} <libri> che ho venduto*
 b. *los libros que he leído y {los/aquellos} <libros> que he vendido*
 the books that have.1SG read and {the/those} books that have.1SG sold
 ‘the books that I’ve read and those that I’ve sold’

Examples (36)-(37) show that definite articles are ruled out in Italian, while the demonstrative *quel* is used without a “true” demonstrative import. In Spanish, on the other hand, both the article and the demonstrative *aquel* can be used, but here the use of *aquel* is clearly related with some distal value.

However, a closer inspection into Italian reveals that the situation is more complex than it appears at first sight: definite articles are not completely excluded from ellipsis environments. Consider the following examples, in which the elided noun is followed by a possessive (36) or by an adjective (37):

- (38) *i libri miei e {i/quelli} tuoi*
 the books mine and {the/that} yours
 ‘my books and yours’
- (39) *la casa rossa e {la/quella} <casa> gialla*
 the house red and {the/that} <house> yellow
 ‘the red house and the yellow (one)’

These examples show that both articles and the weak demonstrative are used in ellipsis, but their distribution differs, depending on the word category of the element following the empty nominal anaphora (Cardinaletti 2024, Pescarini 2024).

The next question is thus what the exact distribution of the two elements is. We have already seen that articles are excluded when the following element is a PP (36) or a relative clause (37). In the case of possessives and adjectives, both articles and demonstratives are accepted (38)-(39).

However, the category of adjectives is particularly complex when it comes to NP-ellipsis. In general, articles are always acceptable in these cases, while the demonstrative *quello* is ungrammatical in two contexts. The first is the case of [+human] silent nouns (Saab 2019), as witnessed by (40) (example taken from Pescarini 2024, but see also Cardinaletti 2024 for similar examples and judgments; capitals stand for silent nouns):

- (40) a. *I cani intelligenti e i <[?]cani>/PEOPLE tonti sono indistinguibili.*
 the dogs intelligent and the <[?]dogs> stupid.PL are indistinguishable
Lit. 'Intelligent dogs and stupid <[?]dogs>/PEOPLE are indistinguishable.'
- b. *I cani intelligenti e quelli <cani>/*PEOPLE tonti sono indistinguibili.*
 the dogs intelligent and that <dogs> stupid.PL are indistinguishable
*Lit. 'Intelligent dogs and stupid dogs/*people are indistinguishable.'*

In these examples, the use of the article (40a) favors an interpretation in which *tonti* 'stupid' is combined with a [+human] silent noun (corresponding to PEOPLE), so that *i tonti* is interpreted as "stupid people". The ellipsis reading is usually less natural, but still available. By contrast, the use of the weak demonstrative *quello* forces the ellipsis reading, while it is impossible to get a silent noun interpretation (40b).¹¹

The second context of NP-ellipsis in which only articles are possible concerns some specific classes of adjectives: ordinal numbers, adjectives like *stesso* 'same', as illustrated in (41):

- (41) a. *Io vivo al primo piano e lui {al/*a quello} secondo.*
 I live at-the first floor and he {at-the/at that} second
'I live at the first floor, and he at the second.'
- b. *Maria ha comprato questo vestito al mercato e Lucia vorrebbe avere {lo/*quello} stesso.*
Maria has bought this dress at-the market and Lucia would.like have the/that same
'Maria bought this dress at the market, and Lucia would like to have the same.'

Note that when an adjective can be used with both an article and a demonstrative, there are usually slight semantic differences between the two. One notable difference is that the cluster

¹¹ This makes sense if, as argued in Saab (2019, 2022a), human empty nouns are just empty concepts, with no indexical or elliptical ingredient. Note that in (40b) the empty noun interpretation is available if we use the "true" demonstrative, which in the case of the masculine plural is different from the weak demonstrative: *quei tonti* 'those PEOPLE stupid' vs. *quelli <cani> tonti* 'those.WEAK stupid'.

‘article + adjective’ can often be interpreted as a nickname, thus as a nominalization (in a similar way to slurs), while this is not the case when a weak demonstrative is used:

- (42) a. *Domani vedi il tuo amico senese o quello <amico> bolognese?*
 tomorrow see.2SG the your friend Senese or that <friend> Bolognese
 ‘Are you meeting your Senese friend or your Bolognese friend tomorrow?’ (ellipsis)
- b. *Domani vedi il tuo amico senese o il ____ norvegese?*
 tomorrow see.2SG the your friend Senese or the Norwegian
 ‘Are you meeting your Senese friend or the Norwegian tomorrow?’ (prevalent nickname reading)

In (42a), the only possible interpretation is that *amico* ‘friend’ has been elided in the second part of the conjunct: there are two friends, one from Siena and one from Bologna. In (42b), instead, the most natural reading is that *norvegese* ‘Norwegian’ is a nickname or, depending on the cases, a title. The second person mentioned in (42b), thus, needs not be a friend of the subject, nor really be from Norway: it is possible that the person got this nickname because of some physical or character trait, e.g., because he has very light blond hair, or because he is reknown as the best skier in town. The ellipsis interpretation is not completely ruled out in (42b), but it is less natural.¹² Table 2 resumes the distribution of articles and demonstratives with empty nouns.

Table 2: Distribution of articles and demonstratives with empty nouns

Element following the empty noun	Use of article	Use of weak demonstrative
PP (36)	No	Yes
Relative clause (37)	No	Yes
Possessive (38)	Yes	Yes
Adjective (with silent nouns) (40)	Yes	No
Adjective (with indexical empty nouns and ellipsis)	Yes, with some categories (but prevalent nickname reading)	Yes, except for some categories of adjectives

¹² Note that there seems to be regional variation concerning the use of the article or demonstrative with adjectives. From an informal survey with linguist colleagues, speakers from the North and Tuscany generally agree with the picture described here, while those from the South tend to use articles in more contexts in which an adjective is present. Thus, for them the ellipsis reading in (42b) might be more natural than (42a). If our analysis is on the right track, it is not a case that the same holds for epithets, where speakers from the South are more permissive in the use of the definite article (cf. fn. 2).

4 Analysis

In this section, we first extend the analysis offered in (4) for Spanish to Italian (§4.1). In the same section, we follow Kornfeld and Saab (2004) and, more specifically, Cardinaletti (2024) and assume that the realization of the D as a weak demonstrative in Italian epithets is accounted for as allomorphic variation at the D head. In §4.2, we end discussing qualitative binominals in Italian with two aims. First, we introduce and adopt the equative analysis of binominals in Spanish in Saab (2022b) and, second, we critically review the recent proposal in Pescarini (2024), according to which there is a further correlation between qualitative binominals and other type of (pseudo)-partitive constructions. We contend that the similarities found in a variety of binominal constructions in which the preposition *di* ‘of’ is involved are not directly related to a partitive syntax but to, again, the underling presence of an indexical ingredient.

4.1 An indexical ingredient in Italian epithets

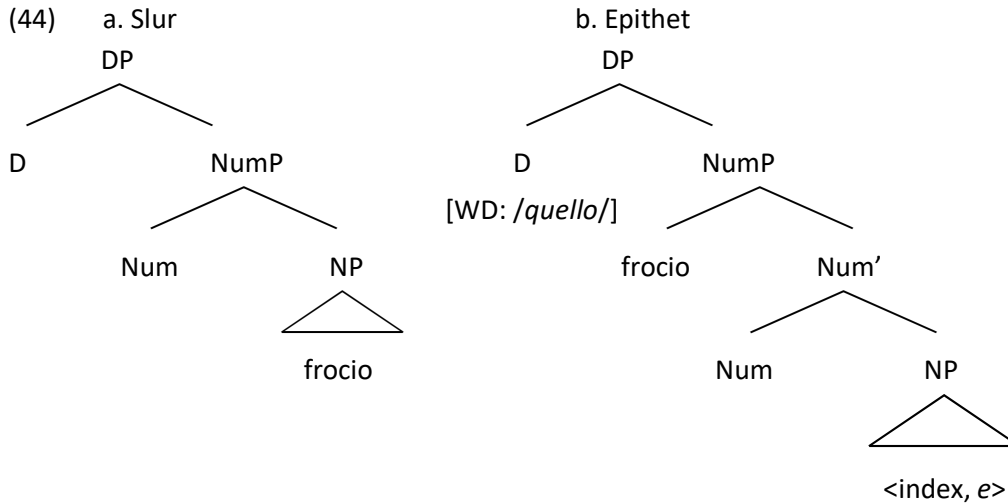
Consider again our initial minimal pair in (6), repeated below:

- (43) a. *È arrivato {il / quel} frocio_s.*
 is arrived {the/that} homosexual_{PEJ}
 ‘The/that f... has arrived.’
- b. *{*il / quel} frocio del tuo amico*
 {the/that} EPITHET of.the your friend
 ‘your friend, that f...’

Following Saab (2022b, 2025a), we propose that Italian epithets involve an indexical empty noun with the epithet in the specifier of some functional projection of the DP (e.g., NumP). As already observed, since epithet constructions like (43b) are not compatible with the (limited) cases of empty nominal anaphora that allow the use of the article (cf. §3.2), they require the use of the weak demonstrative. In turn, slurs occur as canonical nominal predicates and do not show any special requirement on the realization of the D head, which can be instantiated by the full range of determiners in the language. Let’s focus first on simple DPs containing slurs or epithets and then on qualitative binominal constructions.

As we have seen in the previous section, the distribution of slurs and epithets robustly conforms to what we observed for Spanish and English in §2. Therefore, we propose a straightforward extension of the analyses provided in (4) for Spanish to Italian, with the minimal modification

that the D head of epithet constructions is realized as a weak demonstrative (WD = weak demonstrative):



These analyses account for the distribution of slurs and epithets in exactly the same way as in Spanish or English. As we have already shown, Property #1 on the anaphoric nature of slurs and epithets refer to the fact that epithets behave as antilogophoric pronouns and DPs headed by slurs as regular R-expressions. As the examples in (30) illustrate, in antilogophoric environments of the relevant type (i.e., those in which there is a Principle-C violation configuration), the predicative reading of slurs is blocked; in such environments, only the pure expressive reading of an epithet is preserved. The analyses in (44) explains the difference straightforwardly by virtue of the referential nature of each of the constructions under study here. Concretely, DPs headed by slurs are R-expressions, and epithetic constructions, antilogophoric pronouns. This is enough to explain why coreference is possible only under the epithet readings in the examples in (30): since epithets are pronouns, Principle-B is respected in the relevant syntactic contexts, which, in addition, avoid the antilogophoric constraint in (12).

Next, recall that Properties #2 and #3 on intensification and binominal occurrence disambiguate in favor of the epithetic reading in Spanish, English or Italian, while Properties #4 and #5 on nominal ellipsis and restrictive modification disambiguate in exactly the opposite direction, i.e., in favor of the slur reading. Since epithets in non-predicative, modification position are not the head of the entire DP, they allow for the intensifiers as other prenominal modifiers. As for the occurrence in binominals, as we will see in the next section, qualitative binominals are particular instances of the structures in (44b) with an additional equative coda. In the case of slurs, their licensing nominal ellipsis and restrictive modification is just a straightforward consequence of the fact that they are the predicative heads of the DPs in which they occur.

Now, the next question is how to account for the difference between, say, Spanish and Italian regarding the realization of the D head in the structure in (44b). In this respect, we follow the suggestions in Kornfeld and Saab (2004) and Cardinaletti (2024), according to which the occurrence of the weak demonstrative in Italian is resolved as a matter of allomorphic variation at the D node. Concretely, the alternation between the weak demonstrative and other possible competitors is sensitive to the empty nature of the nominal head. Cardinaletti notices that any of the configurations in (45), in which the heads are phonetically empty, triggers insertion of the weak demonstrative:

- (45) a. $[_{DP} \text{quelli} [_{NumP} \text{Num} [_{NP} \text{N}_{human}]]]$
 b. $[_{DP} \text{quelli} [_{NumP} \text{Num} [_{NP} \text{N}_{index}]]]$
 c. $[_{DP} \text{quelli} [_{NumP} \text{Num} <[_{NP} \text{N}]>]]$ (Cardinaletti 2024: 13)

Yet, as Cardinaletti argues, things are more complex since the realization is also sensitive to the remnants/modifiers of the empty nominal head or empty NP (see also the previous section). So, the environments in (45) must be enriched in a way such as to introduce sensitivity to the modifiers of the empty noun/elliptical site (see Table 2). We leave for another occasion a proper formulation of the allomorphic rule.

In sum, as argued in Saab (2022b), the mandatory presence of the demonstrative with Italian epithets follows from the fact that indexical empty nouns and certain types of empty anaphora systematically require the presence of the demonstrative and reject the definite article, in particular with a non-adjectival category as remnant.

4.2 On binominals and weak demonstratives in Italian

Recall that qualitative binominals in Italian also force the presence of the weak demonstrative, since they host an epithet:

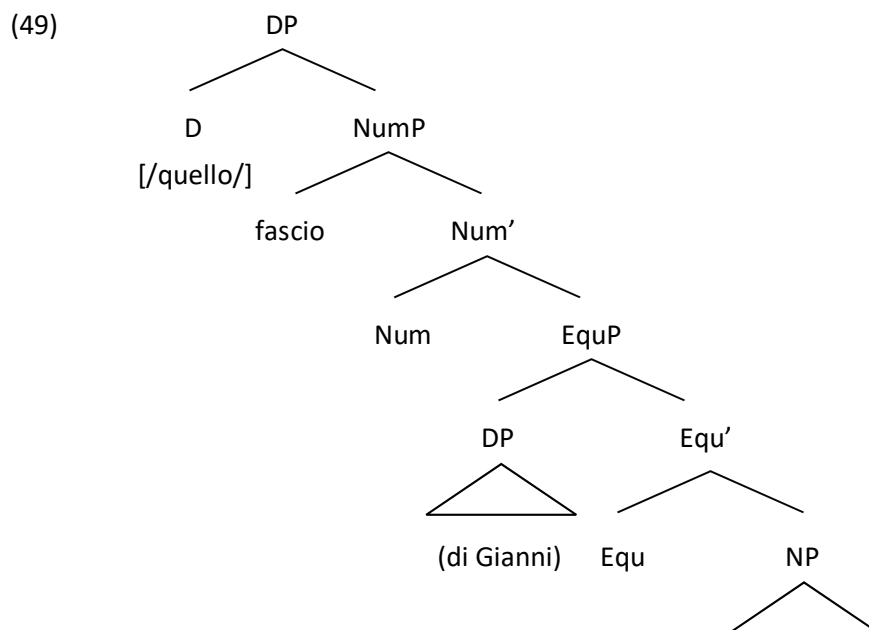
- (46) $\{ *il / quel \}$ *fascio del mio cugino*
 the that fascist of-the my cousin
 ‘my cousin, that fascist’

As it is well known, mainstream approaches to qualitative binominals in Romance and Germanic are conceived of as predicative structures with mandatory predicate raising (den Dikken 2006 and much related work; but see e.g. Massaro 2023 and Cavirani and Wyngaerd 2024 for interesting recent discussion). As argued in Saab (2022a,b), this is incompatible with the Pottsian approach to binominals pursued here. The main evidence in favor of a pure expressive analysis

for epithets comes from our initial paradigm in (1) and (2), repeated below, which clearly shows that epithets do not have any predicative import, against the expectation of the predicate raising analysis:

- (47) a. *Andrés es puto.*
 Andrés is homosexual_{PEJ}
- b. *Ana es puta.*
 Ana is prostitute_{PEJ}
- (48) a. *el puto de Andrés...*
 the EPITHET of Andrés
- b. *la puta de Ana...*
 the EPITHET of Ana

Here, we extend the analysis in Saab (2022b), according to which binominals are the surface reflex of an underlying equative syntax. On this analysis, the weak demonstrative realizes the node D under the conditions discussed in the previous section (i.e., use the demonstrative when the remnant/modifier of the empty indexical is not of (certain) A category). Compared to the mainstream approach to binominals, these are not predicate raising structures but underlying equative constructions in which the *of*-phrase establishes an equative semantic relation with the empty indexical.



<index, e>

See Saab (2022b) for many analytical details and discussion of the predicate raising analysis. For our purposes here, it is important to make explicit how this analysis contrasts with the proposal sketched in Pescarini (2024), according to whom the use of the light demonstrative in nominal anaphora derives from movement of the sequence [*Dem+remnant*] and further NP-ellipsis. Roughly, for a case like *quello bello*, Pescarini proposes the two steps in (50), in which the demonstrative is a light head of a reduced relative clause, which moves crossing the nominal head. Such a movement licenses NP-ellipsis.

- (50) a. *il libro [quello bello]*
 the book that nice
 ‘the nice book’
- b. [*quello bello*] <*libro*>
 that nice book
 ‘the nice one’

According to Pescarini, a set of (pseudo-)partitive constructions in Italian would give support to his analysis. In (51)-(53), there is a set of examples taken from Pescarini: (i) partitives (51), (ii) pseudo-partitives under direct modification (52), and (iii) inverse postnominal modifiers, including participial adjectives, coordinated or modified adjectives, PPs and CPs (53):

(51) Partitives:

- a. *tre (di libri)*
 three of books
 ‘three (books)’
- b. *nessuno (degli studenti)*
 nobody of-the students
 ‘no student/no-one’
- c. *poca (di pasta)*
 little of pasta
 ‘a little (pasta)’

(52) Pseudo-partitives under direct modification:

- a. *i più venduti (di libri)*
 the most sold of books
 ‘the most sold (books)’

b. *il primo (di libro)*
 the first of book
 'the first (book)'

c. *quelli (di libri)*
 those of books
 'those (books)'

(53) Inversed postnominal modifiers such as participial adjectives, coordinated or modified adjectives, PPs and CPs:

a. *quello appeso (di quadro)*
 that hanging of painting
 'the hanging painting/one'

b. *quello caro a papà (di quadro)*
 that dear to dad of painting
 'the painting/one that is dear to dad'

c. *quelli sani e robusti (di alberi)*
 those healthy and strong of trees
 'the healthy and strong trees/ones'

d. *quelle che ho visto (di case)*
 those that have.1SG seen of houses
 'those (houses) that I saw'

Interestingly, Pescarini also includes qualitative binominals as satisfying the relevant structural description:

(54) a. *quel cretino di Giorgio*
 that idiot of Giorgio

b. *quel genio di mio cugino*
 that genius of my cousin

c. *quel vigliacco di un caporale*
 that coward of a corporal

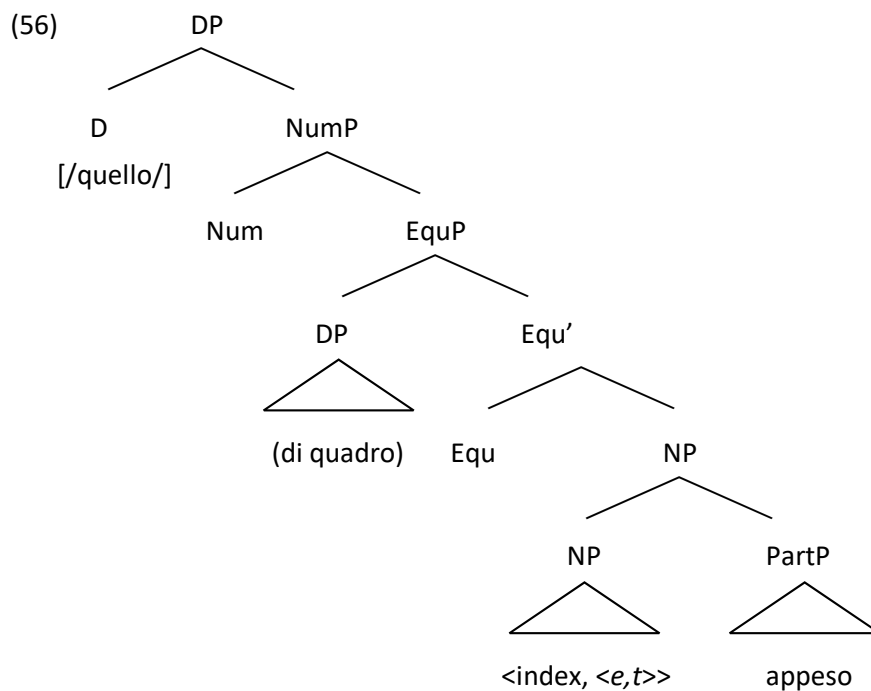
For these qualitative binominals, he proposes a derivation along the lines of (50). Concretely, the [*dem+epithet*] phrase moves crossing the *di*-phrases, and this results in NP-ellipsis:

(55) a. *quel cretino* <[di Giorgio > t]>

b. *quel genio* <[di mio cugino t]>

c. quel vigliacco <[di un caporale] t>

According to Pescarini, then, “NP-Ellipsis in Italian results when the *di*-phrase is not pronounced”. As is well-known, this correlation between partitives, qualitative binominals and nominal ellipsis has a long tradition in the Romance literature (Milner 1978 for a first formal approximation). One prevalent thought is that partitivity licenses ellipsis (Lobeck 1995 and Sleeman 1993, among others). We think that such a correlation is misleading in many respects. Semantically, a myriad of NP-ellipses simply lacks any (pseudo-)partitive semantics. Relatedly, binominals containing epithets also lack any partitive semantics. We conjecture that the right correlation is not between partitives and ellipsis licensing but between (pseudo-)partitives, qualitative binominals and indexicality. Put differently, what unifies the paradigms from (50) to (55) is the underlying presence of an empty indexical, whose semantic type can vary depending on the construction. For instance, for a case like (53a), the underlying structure is also equative, like in qualitative binominals, but with the crucial difference that its underlying index ranges over properties, not entities.



We leave for future research a proper inquiry into this correlation.

5 Conclusion

In this study, we have added a new piece of evidence for the syntactic activity of an indexical ingredient in epithetic constructions. In Jackendoff's (1972) terms, epithets are "special pronouns", in which a pronominal index is ornamented with a pure expressive word in the functional spine of the pronominal structure. Put another way, the mandatory presence of a weak demonstrative in Italian robustly confirms Jackendoff's original view on epithets. As we have shown, weak demonstratives in the language realize the D head whenever there is an empty nominal anaphora in the abstract structure (and other conditions apply).

Before closing this study, we would like to make a brief observation on the Italian expressive term *cazzo* lit. 'dick' (see Doliana 2016, Cuonzo 2019, Vanden Wyngaerd and Cavarani 2024, and Saab 2025a). Consider the following example:

- (57) *Ho lavorato tutto [il cazzo di giorno].*
 have.1SG worked all the.M.SG dick.M.SG of day.M.SG
 'I have worked all fucking day.'

As the English translation shows, the expressive *cazzo* is a good counterpart of expressive adjectives in English and other languages. There is ample evidence that both the syntax and the semantics of this type of expressives are different from the syntax and semantics of epithets (see Saab 2025a for discussion). On the one hand, the *cazzo* construction, like expressive adjectives in English, shows argument extension effects (see Potts 2005, Gutzmann 2019, and Lo Guercio & Orlando 2022, among others), i.e., a type of syntactic-semantic mismatch in which the syntactic argument of the expressive does not match its putative semantic argument. In effect, the most natural reading is that *cazzo* denotes a certain emotional state of the speaker not with respect to days or the day at hand, but with respect to the semantic value of the entire proposition. In simplified terms, the sentence in (57) has the two meaning dimensions in (58), where the frowny face stands for whatever expressive meaning *cazzo* introduces:

- (58) I have worked all day • 😞 (I have worked all day)

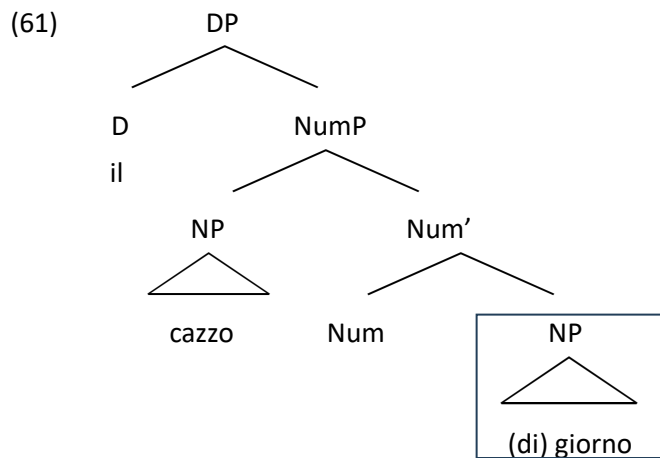
This is never the case with epithets, which always target the expected semantic argument.

On the other hand, syntactically, *cazzo* is invariably masculine and singular, regardless of the gender and number of the noun preceded by the preposition *di*:

- (59) *quella cazzo di lettera*
 that.F.SG dick.M.SG of letter.F.SG
 'that fucking letter' (Vanden Wyngaerd and Cavarani 2024: 340)

- (60) *quei cazzo di articoli*
 that.M.PL dick.M.SG of paper.M.PL
 ‘those fucking papers’ (Vanden Wyngaerd and Cavarani 2024: 341)

Now, to these peculiarities, we would like to add the observation that, unlike binominals containing epithets, the *cazzo* construction does not require the use of the weak demonstrative, such as (57) illustrates. A reasonable analysis, suggested already in Saab (2022a), is to assign to the complement of *di* the status of head of the entire DP, as shown below:



In this structure, *cazzo* forms a natural class with expressive adjectives and *giorno* projects the entire DP. Among other things, this explains why this nominal head is the true controller of gender and number agreement. On this view, following a suggestion already made in Pesetsky (2013), we can conceive of the preposition *di* as the realization of the primeval case of all nominals, namely, genitive (although see Saab 2025c for recent discussion on the primeval genitive hypothesis in the domain of Spanish binominals).¹³

¹³ As shown in Massaro (2023), the counterpart of the *cazzo* construction in Apulian, unlike Italian, does not make use of the preposition *of* in binominals.

- (i) *l-a kaspata l-a bul:et:a* (Apulian; San Marco in Lamis, Foggia)
 DEF-F.SG freaking DEF-F.SG bill
 ‘that freaking thing of a bill’ (Massaro 2023: 146)

Variation in preposition insertion is not dependent on the grammar of particular expressive constructions, but on the way in which languages realize binominals in general. In this respect, as discussed in Massaro’s paper, Apulian allows absence of preposition not only in this expressive environment, but in genitive constructions as well.

So, even if many details remain to be developed in full explicitness, we believe that there are plausible reasons to divide the taxonomy of expressive binominals into: (i) those that contain the indexical ingredient, and (ii) those that do not. In this respect, if our argument in this study is correct, the distribution of weak demonstratives in Italian seems to constitute a robust test for diagnosing implicit indexicals in DPs.

Acknowledgements: to be added later

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Abbreviations

E	epithet
PEJ	pejorative
S	slur

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